Rhetorical Essay 1

The Inseparability of Technology, Politics and Philosophy

Aidan Bugayong

Technologies are subject to complex political systems and ideologies throughout both their creation and deployment into society. Technology is both the cause and the effect of political and philosophical views, rather than a incoherent collection of impartial tools. This essay aims to analyze the inseparability of technology, politics and philosophy by tracing their complex relationships through three key dimensions: its role in our philosophical definition of humanity, its use as an instrument for structuring societies and exercising power, and its ability to release unforseen consequences that shape the philosophical worldviews and the political landscape. Tracing a path from the philosophical definition of humans as tool makers, the use of technology as a political instrument by elites, to even the inherent and unforseen political qualities these creations have on our society.

First, there is a philosophical debate on technologies role as a defining factor as to what makes us human. However, this philosophical debate over what makes us human reveals technology not as a secondary trait but as a core, albeit contested, component of human nature. To start, human nature is often associated with two key parts: “Homo Faber” (Tool Maker) and “Homo Sapiens” (Mind Maker) [Mumford 1966]. Homo Faber refers to the human ability to shape the world through the tools one makes and the technical skills they aquire. On the other hand, Homo Sapien moreso refers to the human ability to understand and explore the world through art, language, and symbolic thought. According to Mumford in “Technics and the Nature of Man”, the prevailing perspective of the 19th century was the notion that man was primarily a tool maker (Homo Faber) as opposed to the mind maker (Homo Sapien). This frames technology as an intrinsic part of human nature and almost even as a form of life, as opposed to a mere physical object or tool.

Despite humans having other essential parts of being a human, such as language, symbolic thought, and art, they are constantly overshadowed by this perspective of man as a tool maker. Leroi-Gourhan in “The Technological Illusion” argued that a skull was not enough to differentiate a human from its more primative counterparts. Rather, it was these skulls being next to stone tools being the indicator for whether or not the skull belonged to a human [Leroi-Gourhan 1960]. On the other hand, Mumford argues that considering humans to be primarily a tool user overlooks the variety of biotechnics that are not preserved through times. Skills like cooking and culture or language can not be identified by looking at a fossil, but are still strong indicators of that fossil belonging to a human. Mumford also believes that defining humans as a tool-using animal would be a rather strange definition for Plato. For Plato, he attributed the rise of man to gods of tools / technology and gods of music / literature equally, which further emphasizes Mumford’s argument that viewing humans as solely tool makers undermines other important qualities that make us humans. As an alternative to this tool centered view, Mumford believes that man is primarily a mind-using, self mastering animal, arguing that “until he had made something of himself, he could make little of the world around him” [Mumford 1966]. This perspective argues that tools are a result of the internal self mastery of humans rather than humans being driven by tools. However, tools are not mere instruments for mastering the external world, they are still intertwined with various forms of human culture. Leroi-Gourhan discussed how he believes the true indicator of being a human is conscious technical activity, which the anatomists determined by presence of tools even if the skulls were to small to have made them. This demonstrates that these tools were more than just the efforts of an individual, rather an integral part of communities shared amongst individuals to aid their development. However, Mumford believes that the more important driving factor toward human development was improvements / the invention of language, capable of expressing and transmitting thoughts and meaning, compared to small efforts of a man and their stone tools [Mumford 1966]. Regardless, this historic back and forth of technology and man is an integral part of what makes us humans according to Leroi-Gourhan, meaning that one cannot possible hope to look at human history and development without looking at technology and their impact on us as humans.

Beyond being a crucial factor in defining humanity, technology has historically acted as a political instrument for the elites to structure societies and solidify their power. This goes far back to ancient civilizations constructing large monumental temples. In Robert Hahn’s “Technologies as Politics: The Origins of Greek Philosophy in Its Sociopolitical Context”, Hahn analyzed ancient greekk societies and argued that the construction of these colossal temples served not only as a display of power (both financial and physical), but also as a physical reminder that legitimizes the power of elites [Hahn 2001]. Hahn also notes that while some building projects were publically sponsored, many projects were not. Some of these projects were specially funded by powerful individuals, whether that be aristocrats, royalty or even tyrants, as a means to serve their own interests. Most importantly, aristocratic ownership of temples and land (and disputes of such ownership) is what gave many aristocrats their powers. According to Hahn, construction of some temples were a way for aristocrats to attempt to preserve their status and land as a way of maintaining ownership and displaying the power of their land. Similarly, in Winner’s “Do Artifacts Have Politics?”, he brings up a more contemporary and modern example of the Robert Moses’s Bridges, which had a low overpass, deliberately designed to discourage the presence of buses on his parkways. Despite the decades old death of Robert Moses, his political decisions continute to affect and shpae the city of New York, “Many of his monumental structures of concrete and steel embody a systematic inequality, a way of engineering relationships among people that, after a time, became just another part of the landscape” [Winner 1986]. Demonstrating how physical infrastructure can prolong this snapshot of a specific social order into the landscape itself. Thus, Robert Moses uses technology as an instrument to strucutre society as he sees fit. Winner further argues that the issues within the people in society are not only a product of political laws and practices, but also within the physical landscape of all our technologies [Winner 1986]. It includes the very design of our environment which structure our own human relationships. Further demonstrating that the little things such as what to build and how to build it can be used as a political instrument by those already in power to further and solidify their status. Demonstrating how the material world we inhibit can be (and partially is) shaped and molded by the interests of the elite in order to preserve and naturalize their power, creating this connection to political structures to technological forms.

The relationship is further complicated because the implementation of technology often unleashes unforeseen consequences, altering the very social and philosophical worlds it was meant to control. Hahn argued that the that the emergence of “the Greek Philosophy that emphasizes rational explantion and the optimism of reason” was a result of the monuments erected by the falling aristocrats as a final effort to “bolster a failing authority” [Hahn 2001]. Despite the aristocrats attempt to maintain their power through these technological structures, they ironically gave birth to a new rational philosophy that challenges the very power they sought to preserve. Additionally, production and innovation of monuments and other structures brought to light relations and laws that contradicted the current mythological worldview of the time, leading towards advancements in the research of nature and the laws that govern it [Hahn 2001]. Further emphasizing the idea that technology shapes our philosophical and societal landscapes. Additionally, Mumford argued that “When not threatened by hostile environmental pressures, man’s elaboration of symbolic culture answered a more imperious need than that for control over the external environment—and, as one must infer, largely predated it and for long outpaced it” [Mumford 1966], meaning that the technology was largely shaped by advancements in human culture rather than the strict need to control the hostile environment. However, Mumford also brought to light the point that technology was also used as a means to maintain and funnel power to the elites (like the aristocrats wanted in Hahn’s reading), Mumford characterized notions of a “megamachine” which was a large collection of human labor in order to follow the will of the elite [Mumford 1966]. Mumford noted things like the pyramids were the result of such machines, emphasizing how these machines were created to influence the societal landscape of their time. Leading to this overarching affect where technology both shapes and is shaped by the complex philosophical and societal landscape that surrounds us to this very day.

Ultimately, technology is far from a neutral artifact of tools. From the importance of tools in human origins, to its deployment as an instrument of political power, technology is fundamentally intertwined with politics and our philosophical views. Subtle choices embedded into the design of structures act as an invisible hand guiding our society to the will of its creator, or at times guiding society to challenge the creator. To ignore technology in the political and philosophical landscape is to misunderstand the very thing that shapes (and is shaped by) our worldviews and the structure of our daily lives.

Works Cited

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